

“For All the Saints”

Text: William Walsham How, 1864

Meter: 10.10.10

Suggested Tune: SINE NOMINE

1. For all the saints who from their labors
rest,
who Thee, by faith, before the world
confessed
Thy name, O Jesus, be forever blest.
Alleluia! Alleluia!
2. Thou wert their rock, their fortress, and
their might;
Thou, Lord, their captain in the well-fought
fight;
Thou, in the darkness drear, their one true
light.
Alleluia! Alleluia!
3. Oh, may Thy soldiers, faithful, true, and
bold,
fight as the saints who nobly fought of old
and win with them the victor's crown of
gold!
Alleluia! Alleluia!
4. O blest communion, fellowship divine!
We feebly struggle, they in glory shine;
yet all are one in Thee, for all are Thine.
Alleluia! Alleluia!
5. And when the fight is fierce, the warfare
long,
steals on the ear the distant triumph song,
and hearts are brave again, and arms are
strong.
Alleluia! Alleluia!
6. The golden evening brightens in the west;
soon, soon to faithful warriors comes their
rest;
sweet is the calm of paradise the blest.
Alleluia! Alleluia!

7. But lo, there breaks a yet more glorious
day;
the saints triumphant rise in bright array;
the king of glory passes on His way.
Alleluia! Alleluia!

8. From earth's wide bounds to ocean's
farthest coast,
through gates of pearl streams in the
countless host
singing to Father, Son, and Holy Ghost:
Alleluia! Alleluia!

Reflection (All Saints Day):

This famous hymn commemorates all saints – not only the popular saints or those who have been canonized by the Church, but all those who populate heaven. The tune which was written for this hymn, SINE NOMINE, was dedicated to those unknown saints. Its title “*sine nomine*” translates from Latin to “without a name.”

The first verse of the text establishes the objective of the hymn. We are honoring all the holy men and women who professed their faith in Christ in their earthly life and have now been rewarded with rest in heaven.

Verses 2-3 frame the spiritual life as warfare. Christ was the captain and fortress of the saints in their earthly life, giving them the strength they needed to win the battle. Now that they have won their share of Christ's victory and enjoy their rest in heaven, we look to them as models in our life. We ask God to give us the same strength that He gave them as we fight our own battles.

Verse 4 acknowledges that, even though we are in different stages of the spiritual life – we are still in battle while they have already

won – we are united with them. There are multiple states of the Church: the Church Triumphant (those who won their battles and enjoy their victory in heaven), the Church Penitent (those in purgatory), and the Church Militant (us, still fighting here on earth). But even though we are physically separated between these different states, we are all members of one Body, the Church.

In verse 5, the text acknowledges that this fight is not easy. We grow weary. It takes a toll on us. But, since we have hope in the coming victory, we continue fighting, renewed with the strength to carry on a little longer.

But soon, in verse 6, we reach the evening of our lives. The outcome is not bleak, but “golden” to those who kept fighting the battle to the end, since they are promised the reward of paradise the next morning. And so, in verse 7, we finally reach daybreak. Resurrected with the saints, we watch Christ the victor pass before us in procession towards His throne in heaven.

The triumph song, which once inspired the saints in verse 5, now resounds throughout creation in the final verse. The triumphant saints process through the pearly gates of heaven and together praise the Triune God who fought alongside them, strengthened them, won the victory for them, prepared a home for them, and loves them.